

A social lion with great charisma, Senator Henry Clay received the Whig Party's presidential nomination in 1832 and 1844, but was unsuccessful both times. He advocated protective tariffs to aid Western development.

“Our federal Union—it must and
shall be preserved.”

ANDREW JACKSON, 1830

Nullification Crisis

Disputes also arose over federal tariffs, or taxes, intended to protect industry in the North. The South resented the tariff because it made European imports into the region more costly. In 1830, South Carolina considered refusing to enforce a tariff passed by Congress in 1828. When another tariff was passed in 1832, South Carolina declared that this and the 1828 tariff were null and void within the borders of the state. Congress denied South Carolina's right to opt out and authorized Jackson to do whatever was necessary to enforce federal law. The Nullification Crisis came to an end in 1833 when South Carolina, finding itself isolated and its claims rejected by other Southern states, backed down.

TARIFFS Customs duties that are levied on certain imported goods. These taxes are usually designed to protect domestic producers of similar goods.

War with Mexico

As Jackson's term ended, his approach to another crisis was more cautious. In the 1820s, many Americans had emigrated to the territory of Texas, and by 1835 were seeking its independence. After trying to negotiate with Mexican leader Antonio López de Santa Anna, the Texans took to arms. In the ensuing hostilities, they rallied from defeat at the Alamo in March 1836 to capture Santa Anna at San Jacinto a few months later. They then established their own republic and inquired about joining the Union. Jackson and his successor, Martin Van Buren, demurred for fear of precipitating war with Mexico. Later presidents were more supportive, however, and in 1845 Texas joined the United States. Mexico rejected the